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THE MEX FACTOR: Lawmakers, gifts and sponsored trips

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A recent CalMatters report shows that in 2024, corporations and nonprofits—many with frequent business before the state—spent more than $820,000 sending dozens of California legislators on trips both domestic and international. While that's less than the $1.1 million spent in 2023, the scope of the practice remains striking: nearly 100 groups sponsored travel for 92 lawmakers, roughly three-quarters of the Legislature. Destinations ranged from nearby Berkeley and Napa to Hawaii, Europe, Southeast Asia, and Israel.

The single largest sponsor was the California Foundation on the Environment and the Economy (CFEE), which paid nearly $260,000 to send more than 40 lawmakers on study tours. CFEE has been the biggest patron of legislative travel for several years running. The nonprofit is unusual in that it brings together representatives from groups often at odds in Sacramento: Big Oil, labor unions, environmental organizations, major corporations, tribes, and trade associations. Companies can pay to join CFEE's board, and some board members travel alongside legislators.

The second-largest travel sponsor was the Independent Voter Project, a nonprofit that promotes voter education on public policy. It spent more than $100,000 on two trips: its long-running annual Maui gathering, attended by 17 legislators, and a cross-border conference in Valle de Guadalupe, Baja California, with six lawmakers. Both trips drew members from both parties.

Unlike many organizations, the Independent Voter Project filed disclosure reports revealing who else attended the Maui trip—over 100 corporate, union, and nonprofit representatives, many with pressing business before the Legislature, including Pacific Gas & Electric, a prison guard union, an oil group, and a hospital trade association.

Under California law, groups must disclose major donors traveling with officials if the trip accounts for at least one-third of their expenses. But a 2024 Fair Political Practices Commission audit found that this threshold creates transparency gaps, since wealthy groups can fund travel without ever triggering the requirement. After a CalMatters report in 2023 exposed how rarely disclosures were filed, the Independent Voter Project began filing them retroactively, accounting for six of the 11 total reports now on record.

Other interest groups also sponsored international travel. The Jewish Community Relations Council and the Jewish Federation of Los Angeles paid nearly $82,000 to send seven Democratic lawmakers to Israel last February. Attendees included Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel and Sen. Scott Wiener, co-chairs of the Legislative Jewish Caucus. Organizers said the trip aimed to strengthen ties between California and Israel and included meetings with Israelis, Palestinians, and members of the Knesset.

Travel isn't the only perk flowing from interest groups to lawmakers. In 2024, elected officials reported nearly $250,000 in gifts, in addition to the $820,000 in sponsored trips. That's down from the $330,000 in gifts reported in 2023. Legislators must disclose gifts worth more than $50, and if they exceed the $590 annual cap from a single source, they must repay the difference.

Altogether, 108 lawmakers reported receiving gifts from more than 450 sources last year, while 12 reported none. The largest single gift source was the California Democratic Party, which gave more than $27,000—mostly in retreats and meals—to 71 lawmakers, including some Republicans.

Disclosure reports illustrate the range of gifts lawmakers accept. Assemblyman Jeff Gonzalez (R-Indio) reported no gifts, trips, or stocks. By contrast, Sen. Steve Padilla (D-San Diego) reported 23 gifts totaling $2,625.90, from entities including the Recording Industry Association of America, the San Manuel Band of Mission Indians, the California Democratic Party, the Chamber of Commerce, and the Legislative LGBT Foundation. His list included

event tickets, lodging, wine, clothing, and even a flag, a candle, and a bandana.

The question remains: do constituents benefit when legislators accept thousands of dollars in sponsored gifts and travel—or do the groups footing the bill gain the greater advantage?

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